

PRD for a Local-First Personal Financial Planner

Product intent

The product should be a single-user, offline-first personal finance application for a working middle-class household that runs locally, persists all data between sessions, and is simple to build, run, and distribute from a GitHub repository. It should give one coherent view of income, spending, debt, net worth, goals, portfolio allocation, retirement accounts, and forward projections, while supporting manual imports from common real-world financial institutions and statement files. The core strategic decision behind the PRD is local-first rather than cloud-first: existing local tools prove that embedded storage and desktop-style operation are viable, while modern consumer and advisor tools show that users now expect much more than a ledger or budget register. SQLite is explicitly documented as appropriate for desktop applications and even financial analysis tools, which makes it a strong persistence baseline for an offline app. ¹

The market gap is clear. Local tools such as Actual Budget, GnuCash, and Moneydance prove that private, on-device finance software can support imports, reports, budgeting, investments, and encrypted local storage. But modern cloud products set user expectations higher: consolidated accounts, searchable transactions, recurring detection, goals, net worth, subscriptions, reports, and planning workflows are now standard in products like Monarch Money ², Copilot Money ³, and Rocket Money ⁴. The opportunity is to combine the privacy and control of local software with the clarity and planning depth of modern money apps and advisor software. ⁵

Market evidence

The most relevant local benchmark is Actual Budget. Its documentation describes it as a local app, supports importing CSV, QIF, OFX, QFX, and CAMT files, exposes a developer API, and now includes first-party reports, tracking budgets, cash-flow and net-worth views, plus custom reports. It also explicitly treats off-budget investment and debt accounts as part of net worth. That combination makes it the best proof that a local-first design can still support modern reporting and extensibility. ⁶

GnuCash and Moneydance show the other side of the market. GnuCash is based on professional accounting principles, supports double-entry bookkeeping, imports financial data, includes budgeting, investment tracking, and more than 30 built-in reports. Moneydance emphasizes privacy, encryption, online banking, budgeting, investment tracking, and reports. These products confirm that the app should not stop at budgeting alone; it should support a serious household balance sheet and cash-flow system. Their main weakness, relative to newer apps, is that they are more accounting-centric than goal-centric. ⁷

Professional advisor software points to the planning features worth borrowing. eMoney Advisor ⁸ markets goals-based planning, cash-flow planning, centralized data, and a client portal with full financial-picture and document storage. RightCapital ⁹ organizes household net worth, goals, and income/savings/expenses, includes cash-flow maps, and explicitly supports goal-based, traditional cash-flow, and modified cash-flow approaches. MoneyGuide ¹⁰ emphasizes goals-based planning, collaborative cash-flow and

estate planning, dynamic net worth over time, and Monte Carlo-based lifetime income analysis. These platforms imply that the offline product should combine four modes instead of picking one: transaction tracking, net-worth tracking, goal tracking, and scenario planning. ¹¹

Modern consumer money apps reinforce the same conclusion. Monarch centers on connected accounts, recurring transactions, reports, goals, investments, and net worth. Copilot centers on spending, budgets, investments, and net worth. Rocket Money emphasizes subscriptions, budgeting, financial goals, spending insights, and net worth. Quicken Simplifi emphasizes spending plans, projected cash flow, reports, investments, and retirement planning. The offline product therefore should not be framed as “a budget app”; it should be framed as a household financial control panel. ¹²

What professional planners track

The most durable planning backbone comes from CFP Board ¹³ and Financial Planning Association ¹⁴. CFP Board defines financial planning as an integrated process around life goals and personal/financial circumstances, and its seven-step framework runs from understanding circumstances and identifying goals through analyzing alternatives, developing recommendations, presenting them, implementing them, and monitoring/updating them. FPA’s educational materials emphasize the same process and explicitly frame planning as client-centered and values-based. This means the application should not only record facts; it should preserve decisions, assumptions, recommendations, and review history over time. ¹⁵

For household finance specifically, professional and educational materials repeatedly anchor on net worth, cash flow, debt, and goals. FINRA ¹⁶ tells investors to calculate net worth to set goals, determine risk tolerance, and estimate how much can be invested. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau ¹⁷ structures its “Your Money, Your Goals” toolkit around spending decisions, debt, income, bills, and practical worksheets. FDIC ¹⁸ continues to position financial capability curricula as practical, stage-of-life money management. Academic-style extension materials from Rutgers Cooperative Extension ¹⁹ and the University of Minnesota similarly emphasize net worth statements, spending plans, debt-reduction goals, record keeping, SMART goals, financial ratios, and periodic review. ²⁰

Investment planning adds three more concepts that strong planners use and most simple budgeting tools ignore. First is asset allocation: the SEC ²¹ explains that allocation among stocks, bonds, and cash is personal and driven by time horizon and risk tolerance. Second is rebalancing: Vanguard ²² describes rebalancing as keeping a portfolio from drifting too far from a target mix as goals and life circumstances change. Third is written investment policy: CFA Institute ²³ positions the investment policy statement as a disciplined guide that integrates objectives, constraints, risk, and rebalancing rules. The product should therefore include target allocation, tolerance bands, rebalancing triggers, and an editable household investment policy note. ²⁴

Risk profiling must also be handled carefully. FINRA highlights investment objectives and risk tolerance as core inputs, while CFA Institute notes that simplistic questionnaires alone are often unreliable. The product should therefore record both structured answers and contextual notes: willingness to take risk, actual capacity to bear loss, liquidity needs, and upcoming liabilities. That distinction matters because a middle-class household can be emotionally comfortable with risk while still lacking short-term cash reserves. ²⁵

PRD

Product vision

Build a local-first household financial planner that gives one trusted source of truth for money. It should act as a personal finance operating system: a place to import statements, review transactions, track assets and debts, monitor net worth, understand allocations, define goals, and run forward-looking scenarios without requiring a cloud account or ongoing hosted backend.

Primary user

A single working middle-class adult, with optional future support for partner or household collaboration. The user manages checking, credit cards, brokerage, retirement accounts, student loans, and savings across multiple institutions, wants literacy and control rather than outsourced advice, and is willing to review imports and maintain categories if the payoff is clear oversight.

Core jobs to be done

The application must let the user answer six recurring questions:

- What did I earn, spend, save, and send this month?
- What do I own, what do I owe, and how has my net worth changed?
- Where is my money allocated across cash, debt payoff, retirement, brokerage, and emergency reserves?
- Am I on track for my goals?
- What happens if income, expenses, debt payments, or market returns change?
- What decisions did I make before, and why?

Functional requirements

Household overview. The home dashboard must show current net worth, liquid cash, monthly income, monthly spending, monthly savings rate, debt balances, upcoming bills, account balances, and allocation by account type and asset class. This requirement is directly supported by what modern consumer apps and advisor platforms expose as their primary value: one place to see the full picture, not a collection of disconnected ledgers. ²⁶

Transaction system. The app must support imported and manual transactions, categorization, merchant/payee normalization, transfer detection, split transactions, tags, notes, attachments, review status, and rules. It should support both cash-flow budgeting and tracking-only accounts. Actual Budget, Chase Spending Planner, and Monarch all reinforce the value of recurring detection, categorizable transactions, and reporting on real transaction history. ²⁷

Accounts and balance sheet. The app must support checking, savings, credit card, loan, student loan, brokerage, retirement, HSA, real-estate asset, manual asset, and liability accounts. Net worth must be computed from all assets less all liabilities; off-budget investment and debt accounts must still appear in the balance sheet. This aligns with FINRA's net-worth framing and Actual Budget's treatment of off-budget tracking accounts. ²⁸

Goals and capital allocation. The app must support debt-paydown goals, emergency-fund goals, sinking funds, down-payment goals, retirement goals, and general savings goals. Each goal needs target amount, target date, linked accounts, monthly required contribution, progress, and variance from plan. The product should also let the user define allocation policies such as “x% of net income to retirement,” “y dollars per month to student loans,” and “keep emergency fund at z months of core expenses.” Consumer and advisor products both make goals first-class objects; the offline app should do the same. ²⁹

Investment and market allocation. The app must track holdings, tickers or fund names, quantity, cost basis when available, account wrapper, asset class, tax treatment bucket, target allocation, current allocation, drift, and rebalancing flags. It must support household-level rollups across taxable, tax-deferred, and tax-free buckets, because advisor tools and investment guidance consistently treat allocation, risk, and rebalancing as portfolio-level decisions. ³⁰

Planning and projections. The app must support deterministic projections first: projected balances, savings accumulation, debt payoff dates, emergency-fund runway, and retirement contributions based on editable assumptions. It should also support scenario planning with alternative assumptions for income growth, inflation, debt prepayment, investment return, and contribution changes. A later phase may add probabilistic modeling, because advisor software commonly uses Monte Carlo in lifetime-income planning, but the MVP does not need institutional-grade simulation if deterministic scenarios are strong and transparent. ³¹

Decision memory. The app must preserve assumptions, reviews, and plan notes. Every major change to a goal, allocation target, debt plan, or projection should have an effective date and optional rationale. This requirement comes directly from professional planning practice, where recommendations, assumptions, and monitoring updates are part of the plan itself. ³²

Scope by release

MVP. Local accounts; encrypted persistence; CSV/QFX/OFX/QIF imports; PDF attachment storage; transaction review; categories/rules; dashboard; net worth; cash flow; debt tracking; savings goals; allocation rollups; deterministic projections; backup/export; GitHub-friendly local run and packaged desktop release.

Later release. Better PDF parsing; statement templates per institution; richer investment analytics; tax bucket analysis; partner mode; optional read-only quote refresh when online; optional Monte Carlo; optional FDX-based connectivity if online features are ever added. FDX is relevant because it is the emerging standard around permissioned financial data and explicitly emphasizes control, access, transparency, traceability, and security. ³³

Out of scope for now. Direct bill pay, trade execution, robo-advice, tax filing, live credential scraping, multi-tenant cloud sync, and social/accountant portals.

Data imports and source readiness

Your listed institutions already justify a file-first import strategy. Robinhood supports custom account activity reports as downloadable CSV files and also exposes monthly statements and trade confirmations.

Chase lets desktop users download transactions in CSV, QFX, QIF, and QBO formats for the last two years, and also offers transaction PDFs. Wells Fargo supports downloading account activity to spreadsheet format and Quicken Web Connect, with up to 18 months available for some account types. Wealthfront supports Quicken export through QFX files. Edfinancial lets users view account history and export it to spreadsheet software, while also providing monthly statements. Sequence provides CSV downloadable reports and official PDF account statements. Vanguard plan accounts provide transaction confirmations and quarterly account statements online, and Vanguard documents also reference downloadable transactions to personal finance software. TruStone's public FAQs clearly confirm digital statements and tax-form access, but publicly visible documentation did not clearly confirm CSV/QFX export, so TruStone should be treated as statement-first until verified in implementation. ³⁴

That heterogeneity drives the import architecture. The application should standardize first on structured files that multiple local finance apps already support: CSV, OFX, QFX, and QIF. PDF statements should be treated as a fallback ingest path for balances, activity summaries, and attachments, not as the primary normalized transaction source, because structured formats are more reliable and already available from several of your institutions. Existing local products validate this priority: Actual Budget supports CSV/QIF/OFX/QFX/CAMT, GnuCash supports QIF and CSV/OFX/QFX workflows, and Moneydance supports online banking and downloaded transactions. ³⁵

The import pipeline should therefore have five stages: file intake, parser selection, normalization, duplicate detection, and review. Each imported row should become a normalized event with source institution, account, date, amount, sign, payee, memo, currency, source file hash, and parser version. Nothing should post silently into the ledger without a review queue unless the user explicitly trusts a parser/rule combination. This is a product requirement, not just an engineering preference, because different institutions export different date conventions, memo formats, and transfer representations. The app should assume messy data and make reconciliation a first-class workflow. ³⁶

Security and persistence

Offline does not remove the need for security; it changes the threat model. The main threats become local device access, accidental leakage through backups or logs, repository mistakes, and mishandling of imported statements. The storage layer should therefore be encrypted at rest. SQLCipher is designed specifically for transparent AES-256 encryption of SQLite databases and is explicitly meant for embedded application databases. OWASP guidance reinforces that keys should not be hard-coded, should not be checked into version control, and should be stored separately from encrypted data whenever possible. ³⁷

Persistence requirements are straightforward. The application database should be the local source of truth and should survive restarts, upgrades, and offline-only use. SQLite is well suited because it is frequently used as the on-disk file format for desktop applications, including record-keeping and financial-analysis tools, and because it simplifies backup and portability. But SQLite also creates temporary and journal/WAL files during processing, so the security model must account for those files as part of encrypted storage, cleanup, and backup behavior. ¹

The security baseline for MVP should include encrypted database storage, optional app unlock via passphrase, separation of keys and data, restrictive file permissions, and encrypted backups. Imported statements and attachments should either be stored inside the encrypted database or in an encrypted sidecar document store with hashes tracked in the database. Logs must never contain account numbers,

balances, raw statement content, or secrets. If future online connectivity is ever added, the product should follow FDX-style permissioning principles and avoid storing raw institution credentials. 38

ADR handoff and open questions

This PRD points toward a small set of architectural decisions for a later ADR. The first is app shell: a cross-platform desktop wrapper is appropriate, but the ADR should weigh setup simplicity against binary size and runtime complexity. The second is storage: encrypted SQLite is the highest-confidence baseline. The third is import strategy: structured-file parsers first, institution templates second, PDF parsing third. The fourth is projection engine: deterministic scenarios first, probabilistic modeling later. None of those choices need to be settled in the PRD, but the PRD does narrow the architecture substantially. 39

Open questions remain. Publicly visible documentation did not clearly confirm downloadable transaction formats for TruStone credit-card data, so implementation should assume statements-first there. Vanguard clearly supports plan statements and confirmations, but publicly surfaced pages were less specific about exact downloadable transaction file types for employer-plan records than for other institutions. Sequence and Robinhood export coverage is useful but may not cover every account subtype. Finally, professional-grade Monte Carlo and tax optimization are desirable, but the research supports them more as later-stage planning features than as minimum requirements for a robust local MVP. 40

The highest-confidence product definition is therefore this: a local-first household finance system with encrypted persistence, file-based imports, strong transaction review, a true balance-sheet view, explicit goals, allocation tracking, and transparent scenario modeling. That is the smallest product that still reflects how serious planners actually think about money, rather than how simple budget apps merely total expenses. 41

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